capability.” Regarding resilience, a country with a small territory and high population density and concentration of infrastructures in a relatively small area requires the ultimate deterrence. If deterrence fails, there is a danger that one barrage could incapacitate the country. Second-strike capability strengthens deterrence, as it conveys to the enemy that it does not have the ability to defeat you. In addition, with your second-strike capability you may be able to defeat the enemy, or at least inflict enough damage to convince it that its decision to initiate the first strike was unwise.

The National Intelligence Assessor

The structure of the State of Israel’s intelligence community— Military Intelligence (MI), the Institute for Intelligence and Special Operations (the Mossad), and the General Security Service (Shabak)— was established in the early 1950s by the first prime minister of the independent State of Israel, David Ben-Gurion. As an avowed democrat, he correctly believed that the unnecessary concentration of power in the hands of one body should be prevented as much as possible. He recognized that intelligence is power and that an intelligence community must therefore be built in such a way that there is no single center of power. An excess of power has the potential for corruption and abuse.

Ben-Gurion decided then that the head of MI would be subordinate to the defense minister, through the IDF chief of staff; the heads of the Mossad and the Shin Bet would be subordinate to the prime minister. The cynics asked what the value in this was, as Ben-Gurion filled both of these roles at the time, so that all the power would be concentrated in his hands anyway! The answer to this question lies in the historic story of the establishment of the state. Ben-Gurion understood that the only guarantee for the survival of this miracle called the State of Israel was to establish a strong IDF as quickly as possible. He took this task upon himself, in his capacity as minister of defense. Once the state was established and the IDF would indeed be able to guarantee its survival, the time would come to implement the principle of the decentralization of power in the intelligence community.

Ben-Gurion defined not only the hierarchy of the young intelligence community but also the areas of responsibility and the boundaries of the three intelligence services. The IDF Intelligence Corps is supposed to be the most central and largest service, since it is responsible for early warning and